been a big step in the right direction.'

Kesar Kumar, an 18-year-old Class 12 student, declared: 'I had been running this library for my fellow prisoners, and I was happy that a lot of them visited this place frequently and spent considerable time here. Even the jail superintendent took a book from here whenever he visited the ward. Earlier, of course, I couldn't have run a place like this because I would not have got any support or encouragement from anyone. We made our choice of books be known through the petition box or through the forum.'

Bhupinder Singh, another 18-year-old, came to Tihar in June 1993 as an undertrial in a murder case. He stated that he was terribly afraid of what he thought lay in store for him in jail: 'Before coming here I had the impression that the jail would be a terrible place – like what I had seen in the movies, that we all would have to wear the same dress, and there would be beatings and the food would be terrible. But it was not like that at all. As a matter of fact, it was more like a school hostel, where all of us were of the same age group. There was a lot of friendship amongst us.'

Deputy Superintendent Gupta described the administration's efforts towards educating the prisoners: 'We had a clear-cut policy on education. Whoever was imprisoned here must go out literate or better educated than what he was. On entry, the prisoner was classified according to his literacy status. The illiterates were taught the alphabet and learnt to read and write within a couple of weeks. The others were divided into groups and joined their respectively graded classes. The teachers were selected from amongst the prisoners themselves and their dedication to their job must be seen to be believed. And as an incentive they received up to Rs 200 per month. For half the day the jail was like a school, with classes and language courses going on everywhere.'

Sardar Singh, 50 years old and an undertrial under the NDPS Act for the past few years, was almost stoic about his situation. He had quite accepted the fact that given the system with which the country had to live, such Acts will be misused. Nevertheless, he had not given up hope: 'But, somehow, and at least in my case, we got so involved in our activities here that we didn't know when morning turned to night.'

Sardar Singh, popularly known as Guruji, and addressed as such by the IG (P) herself, was overall in charge of the education cell of the juvenile wards. As he himself observed:

> I started off as an adult educator in Jail 3, in 1989, but now I've been given charge of these wards. The inmates here were quite an indisciplined lot initially with just about 20 to 30 boys interested in studies. The rest would roam round the ward compound and mostly be arguing and fighting with each other. But [soon] they started sitting in organized groups and regular classes were being held. Those who did not have a class going on visited the library and were content to spend a lot of time there.
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> I felt this had been made possible by the fact that all the jail staff now appeared to be very helpful. Whatever suggestions we made to them were heard and the required help was extended. This had resulted in this ward appearing almost like a residential school.
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> This much I can say … Before they were involved in this school-like discipline, the boys were mostly thinking about their condition here, their homes and all sorts of related problems. This would make them morose, or hyperexcitable, and that would affect both their physical as well as mental health.
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> I told these students of mine, whatever be the circumstances you face at present, the humaneness in you must come out in the future. What's happened is the past, and you have no control over it. But the future is something you can prepare yourself for. That is what we were